

Isaac Tucker

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Education

- 2021 - 2027 Ph.D. in Management - UCLA Anderson
Committee: Olav Sorenson, Robert Fairlie, Ashvin Gandhi, David Rigby
Job Market Paper: Performance as a Random Variable
Dissertation: Worker Volatility and Strategic Human Capital
- 2011 - 2012 M.A. in Geopolitics and the Global Economy - University College Dublin
- 2008 - 2011 B.A. in Geography - University of California, Los Angeles

Research

Performance as a Random Variable

(Job Market Paper)

Individual performance is stochastic, but strategic human capital research evaluates workers and policies only in terms of mean or expected performance. This omission embeds strong, rarely stated assumptions about organizations' ability to absorb bad draws and capitalize on good ones. Using a portfolio model, I show that many small, poor, fragile or interdependent organizations pay a "Volatility Tax" and should favor reliability. Large, well-capitalized, or modular organizations can ignore the spread of performance and focus only on the mean. I develop this insight as Human Capital Portfolio Management and discuss implications for strategy, entrepreneurship, and organizational theory.

Playing the Spread: Worker Volatility and Human Capital Management

(Part of Dissertation)

Workers have good days and bad days, but HR and HCM research overwhelmingly focuses on mean performance. This paper examines whether organizations recognize and price worker volatility when they can measure it, and whether they should. In two studies using data from professional basketball, I document both wage and normative penalties for volatile workers. After separating trait volatility from playing-time noise, more volatile players earn less on the margin where contracts are negotiable. A difference-in-differences design exploits the quasi-random timing of injuries as an identifying shock: holding mean performance fixed, losing a reliable rotation player inflicts a larger penalty on team point differential and win probability than losing a volatile one, and the price teams pay for reliability is consistent with its production payoff. The market nevertheless leaves reliability underpaid. I show that the steadiest rotation players are nearly as costly to lose as high-mean stars, at forty percent of the salary. Taken together, these results suggest that performance management is a portfolio problem, and worker volatility is an important and under-researched opportunity for strategic action.

Searching for Serendipity

(with Martin Gonzalez-Cabello and Olav Sorenson)

Revise and Resubmit at *Strategic Management Journal*

Serendipity would seem to preclude purposeful search. To understand the relationship between search and the probability of serendipitous discovery, we build a formal model of the process, an extension of the NK model. We show that searchers guided by theory find unexpected solutions to their problems far more often than error-prone or random agents. Those who search longer, regardless of the reason, more frequently encounter solutions to problems that they had not been trying to solve. But these unanticipated use cases may represent distractions: our simulations also suggest that those searching might have found even better solutions to their original problems had they not been seduced by their serendipitous discoveries.

Mapping Knowledge Space and Technological Relatedness in US Cities

(with Dieter F. Kogler and David L. Rigby)

European Planning Studies (2013), 21:9, 1374-1391

An outgrowth of my M.A. dissertation.

Work in Progress

Theory-Based Learning and the Ecology of Ideas (with Olav Sorenson)

Shake the Snowglobe: Platform Search and Content Discovery (with Angela Tran)

Conference Presentations

2026 - Consortium on Competitiveness and Cooperation

2026 - Academy of Management Annual Meeting (planned)

2026 - Strategic Management Society Annual Meeting (planned)

Teaching

2025 - 2026 Entrepreneurship and Venture Initiation - Lead Instructor

2025 - 2026 Introduction to Strategy - TA for Tim Gubler

2024 - 2025 Market Entry Strategy - TA for Marvin Lieberman

2024 - 2025 General Management - TA for Ian Larkin

2023 - 2024 Introduction to Strategy - TA for Ashvin Gandhi

2022 - 2023 Entrepreneurship and New Venture Initiation - TA for Olav Sorenson

2022 - 2023 Private Equity and Venture Capital - TA for Olav Sorenson

Service

2026 Reviewer - Journal of Business Venturing

2026 Reviewer - Academy of Management Annual Meeting

2026 Admit Day Coordinator for Strategy, M&O, BDM, and Marketing

2022 - 2024 Admit Day Coordinator for Strategy Department

Professional Experience

2018 - 2021 Chief Product Officer - BlackLine
2016 - 2018 Vice President, Product Management - BlackLine
2015 - 2016 Director, Product Management - BlackLine
2013 - 2015 Director, Mid-Market Sales and Marketing - BlackLine
2012 - 2014 Director, Digital Marketing - BlackLine
2009 - 2012 Solutions Consultant - BlackLine

Community

2022 - Founding Board Member and Chair - Los Angeles Public Press
2020 - 2023 Member | Board Member - California Donor Table
2019 - 2022 Member - Voices for Progress